

Statements — how to use in *Opinion*

Daily Gamecock *Opinion*

J.C. Vaught, Opinion Editor. Fall 2025

Purpose & Scope

This guide explains *when* to ask for an official statement, *how* to ask by email, and provides templates and examples for contacting universities, government agencies, companies, and other institutions. It is written for the Daily Gamecock *Opinion* section, but the practices apply broadly across student and professional journalism.

1 When you must seek a statement (*right of reply*)

Seeking comment is both an ethical obligation and a practical legal safeguard:

- **Criticism or allegations:** If an opinion piece criticizes a person or institution, you must ask them to respond before publication.
- **Potentially harmful assertions:** If your draft includes claims that could affect someone's reputation (e.g., negligence, incompetence, discrimination), offer a fair chance to respond; this can help demonstrate lack of malice and reduce libel risk.
- **Policy or decision coverage:** When discussing university or government *actions*, seek on-the-record reasoning, timelines, or corrective steps from the relevant office (PIO/press office, dean, agency spokesperson).

When it's optional but smart. If an opinion piece is primarily praise or personal reflection, comment is optional; however, if you cite new facts or statistics about an institution, confirm those details or offer a chance to clarify.

2 Who to contact

1. **Universities:** Start with the *media relations/communications* office. Your editor should have a contact there.
2. **Government:** Identify the agency's press office or public information officer (PIO); for elected officials, the press secretary. If facts hinge on records, consider a public-records

request in parallel (FOIA/state open-records).

3. **Companies/nonprofits:** Use the media relations email or the executive responsible for the policy at issue; many list a press inbox specifically for *requests for comment*.

3 How to ask (email anatomy)

Subject line

Include outlet, topic, and a clear deadline. Concise subjects that signal the outlet and topic help sources triage quickly. Examples:

- Request for comment - USC housing waitlist concerns
- Media request (Daily Gamecock) - Student fees oversight

Opening and context

- Identify yourself and the *Daily Gamecock*.
- State the *opinion thesis* you are testing.
- List *specific* questions tied to that thesis.

Ground rules on attribution

Default is **on the record**. The Daily Gamecock does not accept “Off the record” or “on background” sources and statements without explicit approval from the managing editors. If a source requests background for safety or sensitivity, confirm the terms with your editors.

Reasonable time & follow-up

Give institutions a fair window to respond relative to your publication schedule; document attempts to reach them and note “declined to comment” only after bona fide efforts. If time is short, say so explicitly and offer phone availability for faster turnaround.

4 Email templates (copy, customize, send)

A. University

Subject: Request for comment — [Topic]

Hello,

I'm [Name], an opinion writer with the *Daily Gamecock*. I'm writing about [*thesis in one sentence*].

To ensure fairness and accuracy, could I get a statement on the following?

1. What specific policies or constraints led to [issue] this semester?
2. What steps, if any, will USC take before [date] to address [concrete fix]?
3. How should affected students seek help in the meantime (office, link, timeline)?

Thank you,

Name

Daily Gamecock | [email] | [phone]

B. Government agency

Subject: Media request (*Daily Gamecock*) — [Agency] comment on [policy]

Hello [Press Officer],

I'm covering [policy/action] and its impact on [group]. For accuracy, please provide on-the-record responses to:

1. What is the agency's stated rationale and legal authority for [action]?
2. What data informed the decision? Please link to any public reports.
3. What recourse is available to affected students/residents?

Thank you,

Name

Daily Gamecock | [email] | [phone]

C. Company/nonprofit

Subject: Request for comment — [Company] policy on [issue]

Hello,

In a forthcoming column about [issue], I’m asking [Company] to respond on the record to:

1. Current policy on [specific practice] as it applies to students.
2. Any planned changes and the timeline.
3. Your response to critiques that [one-sentence critique].

Thank you,

Name

Daily Gamecock | [email] | [phone]

D. Short-notice follow-up / voicemail script

Subject: Quick follow-up for comment by **2 p.m. ET today** — [topic]

Hi [Name] — following up on the note below. My print deadline is **2 p.m. ET today**. Even a brief statement addressing items #1–#2 would be appreciated. I’m at [phone] and can read the questions aloud if helpful. Thank you.

Voicemail: “Hi, this is [Name] with the *Daily Gamecock*. I’m requesting comment on [topic] by [deadline/timezone]. My questions are [one-line list]. Please call [phone] or reply to [email]. Thank you.”

5 Examples (good vs. needs work)

Good

Subject: Request for comment by 4 p.m. ET — Student fee transparency

Identifies outlet and deadline; states thesis; asks concrete, answerable questions; offers phone; clarifies on-the-record.

Needs work

Subject: Question

Vague subject; no deadline; asks for “any comment” without context; only background questions; no attribution terms.

6 Documentation & transparency

- Keep a log of *who*, *when*, and *how* you sought comment (email, phone, in-person); save screenshots.
- If no response (generally 48hrs), write: “The university did not respond to questions by publication time.”

7 Quick checklist

1. **Is there criticism or an allegation?** If yes, *seek comment*.
2. **Have you written the thesis clearly** in your request?
3. **Are the questions specific** (who/what/when/how) and answerable?
4. **Did you contact the right person/office** and provide a phone number?
5. **Did you document attempts** and fairly characterize non-responses?